



La Cérémonie

Director: Claude Chabrol

©/Presented by: MK2 Productions, France 3

Cinéma, Prokino-Filmproduktion, Olga-Film

(Munich), Zweites Deutsches Fernsehen

With the participation of: Canal+,

Centre national de la cinématographie

With the support of: Procirep,

Productions Traversière

Produced by: Marin Karmitz

Co-producer: Ira von Gienanth

Co-producer (ZDF): Christoph Holch

Production Manager: Yvon Crenn

Unit Production Manager: Catherine Pierrat

Production Team/Administration:

Gisèle Vuillaume, Aline Corneille,

Bruno Bernard, Henry Le Turc

Assistant Director: Cécile Maistre

Assistant Direction: Daphne Rosenbom,

Pierre Armengol, Anne Perron

Script Supervisor: Aurore Chabrol

Adaptation/Dialogue: Claude Chabrol,

Caroline Eliacheff

With the participation of: Monsieur Ousama Rawi

Based on the novel A Judgement in Stone by:

Ruth Rendell

Director of Photography: Bernard Zitzermann

Aerial Photographers: Charlet Recors,

Vincent Kotwas

Camera Operator: Michel Thiriet

Camera Assistants: Sophie Charrière,

Fabienne Delaleau

Grips: Jean-Baptiste Dutreix,

Dominique Robert, Eric Bonnaire

Electricians: Jean-Pierre Baronsky,

Éric Baraillon, Richard Vidal, Michel Garçon

Stills Photography: Jérémie Nassif

Special Effects: Dominique Colodant,

Jean-Pierre Moricourt

Editor: Monique Fardoulis

Assistant Editors: Florence Poulain,

Olivier Rossignol

Art Director: Daniel Mercier

Set Decorators: Yvan Niclass,

Vincent Stadelmann, Pierre Galliard,

Jean-Paul Trincat, Didier Dubedout,

Marie Taulen

Costume Designer: Corinne Jorry

Costumes: Paule Mangelot, Hélène Robin,

Anne-Marie Castaño-Padovan

Make-up/Hair: Thi Loan Nguyen,

Jocelyne Lemery, Cédric Chami

Titles/Opticals: Centimage

Laboratory: LTC St-Cloud

Music: Mathieu Chabrol

Music Director: Laurent Petitgirard

Sound: Jean-Bernard Thomasson, Claude Villand

Sound Assistants: Philippe Richard,

Christian Fontaine, Jean-Louis Lebras

Sound Effects: André Naudin, Gadou Naudin

Cast:

Isabelle Huppert (*Jeanne*)

Sandrine Bonnaire (*Sophie*)

Jacqueline Bisset (*Catherine Lelièvre*)

Jean-Pierre Cassel (*Georges Lelièvre*)

Virginie Ledoyen (*Melinda*)

Valentin Merlet (*Gilles*)

Julien Rochefort (*Jeremie*)

Dominique Frot (*Madame Lantier*)

Jean-François Perrier (*priest*)

Ludovic Brillant

Claire Chiron

Claire-Marie Dentraygues

Claude Chabrol: Elements of Crime

La Cérémonie

SPOILER WARNING The following notes give away some of the plot.

In recent years, Claude Chabrol's films with the actress Isabelle Huppert have epitomised the best and worst of his work. *Une affaire de femmes* (1988), based on the true story of a woman who was put on trial for being an abortionist during the Vichy years, was an exceptionally powerful and contentious piece. In contrast, the only positive thing to be said about the lacklustre adaptation of Flaubert's *Madame Bovary* (1991) was that it induced exactly the boredom in the viewer that the eponymous heroine was trying to escape from. With *La Cérémonie*, the director reinstates his reputation, and while it might not be a full comeback for the man who made *Le Boucher* or *Les Bonnes Femmes*, it is an apt reminder of what he is capable of. It's easy to see why he might be attracted to the work of Ruth Rendell: her thrillers, like his, are commonly concerned with the prelude to murder rather than its aftermath, and her interrogations of English class-bound society find their corollary across the Channel on the bleak, slate-grey Brittany coast.

La Cérémonie fits nicely with a recent spate of films featuring pairs of transgressive female outsiders, particularly those dealing with class, such as Michael Winterbottom's *Butterfly Kiss* and Nancy Meckler's *Sister, My Sister*. But then Chabrol himself has always been interested in transgressive women, whether in his bleak, bizarrely humoured film about the sundering of a lesbian relationship, *Les Biches*, or the more pedestrian *Violette Nozière*, in which Huppert plays a young woman who kills her parents. Certainly there is a feminist streak pursued throughout his career from *Les Bonnes Femmes* (1960) to *Une affaire de femmes* (1988), one which *Madame Bovary*, had it been any good, would have continued. In *La Cérémonie*, Jeanne and Sophie are depicted as isolated, working-class women, who become friends, at the rather pushy behest of Jeanne, because there is no one else around. Jeanne also has another agenda, for crucially these two women also trail ambiguous pasts. In both their cases, the law could not prove conclusively whether they were guilty of murdering their kin.

With darkly hollowed eyes and a severe fringe that makes her face appear more gauntly angular than ever, Sandrine Bonnaire plays Sophie as a haunted woman. Within minutes of the beginning, she establishes an odd presence. The questions of Mme Lelièvre (played with haute bourgeois polish by Jacqueline Bisset) meet with perfunctory, clipped replies. Even an event as explicable as her not meeting Mme Lelièvre on the right train platform hints at something more sinister. Asked whether she likes her small, dark attic bedroom, she says, 'I don't know'. It becomes a common refrain to other polite questions. Sophie works for the family with a robotically neat zeal, but, when left in the kitchen on her own, she picks at a chicken carcass like a hungry animal. She plays the servile role without a murmur, but there is something gnawing away inside her. Her illiteracy soon becomes evident and Bonnaire, her face taught with frustration, succinctly expresses the feelings of someone alienated from the written word – and hence viewed, by the Lelièvres at least, as a social problem. One scene finds her in the library, the shot angled so that she looks very small amongst all the books. Sophie is construed as someone who would prefer to dodge what for her is evidently a painful problem

Jean-Pierre Descheix
Penny Fairclough
Alain François
David Gabison
Pierre Gondard
Claire Ifrane
Philippe Languille
Philippe Le Coq
Joëlle Legua
Christophe Lemoine
Christine Melcer
Sarah Maze-Lauray
Melanie Maudire
Serge Rousseau
Yves Verhoeven
France-Germany 1995©
112 mins
Digital 4K

The screening on Thu 1 Oct will include an extended intro on queer Chabrol by academic Kit Francis Bradbury Rance

With thanks to
Tamasa Distribution

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rather than confront it. When M. Lelièvre calls and requests her to look for a file for him, she slams the phone down and hides away in her room with the television blaring, gobbling up a bar of chocolate like a petulant adolescent.

Chabrol emphasises the girlish quality in both women – at one point they sport pigtales. Together they are like teenagers with a slight crush on each other (any lesbian subtext is otherwise ignored). Huppert's Jeanne is brash and nosy. Her garish choice of nail-varnish (such is the detailed scrutiny of character here that the colour changes on a daily basis) and her short kilts point her out as someone who wants to cut a dash in a small town and to defy restrained, parochial notions of taste. It is Jeanne who goads Sophie into being a 'bad' girl, defying not just the Lelièvres but also the parsimonious and snobby priest (Jean-François Perrier, doing a delightfully plummy turn). As such Chabrol ensures that we are sympathetic to the rebellion.

The two women are set in strong contrast to the Lelièvres. While Sophie and Jeanne are preoccupied with television game shows, the family listens to Elgar and watches *Don Giovanni* on their larger set. As one might expect, Chabrol has fun with these haute bourgeoisie. At first they express anxiety at the idea of having a servant and ponder exactly how they might address Sophie, but they warm up to the idea and are soon ignoring her while she serves their elegant dinners. During the denouement, the Lelièvres not only drink champagne while watching the opera broadcast but dress up for it too. It is with no uncertain irony that they meet their demise, shot with their own hunting guns. As for the two perpetrators, the script is equally playful with their fate. In the faux-religious finale, Jeanne is indirectly killed by the pompous priest, who confirms, 'it was fate'. Meanwhile the wraithlike Sophie walks past the accident, with the blue police lights blurring, into the night to the elegant strains of *Don Giovanni*.

Lizzie Francke, *Sight and Sound*, March 1996